

Banks respond

Banks have agreed to give 'clean' loans to telcos after the heavy bidding for 3G spectrum allocation. This means there will be no specific security required

Fusion coming soon

There have been rumours that AMD's Fusion will be out before the years end instead of the expected 2011 release

those wanting the goodness of a sweet QWERTY keypad and Blackberry Messenger and their famous pop mail service, but not willing to pay above Rs. 20,000 for such a device. Sure, the body isn't typical Blackberry in terms of look and build, but it's a good chunk of dough less and not a bad deal for it. Although, we figure the likes of the Nokia E71/E72 will have something to say about that.

Blackberry Curve 8900

This is a very neat looking phone with a chrome bezel that runs around the phone with a wider accent towards the bottom. The phone's battery cover has a brushed aluminium finish but is plastic. The keypad is slightly different from the higher end Blackberry Bold devices and similar to the Curve 8520. There is a slight gap between each key making each of the keys slightly smaller. However, there's no difference in the finger-to-key contact area since all Blackberry handsets have keys with a raised strip in the middle and the rest of the key tapers inwards either side. In fact this segregated keypad feels just as good, and first impressions actually rate it's keypad as more usable than the Bold 9700.

The trackball can get a touch unresponsive as the device wears with daily use. A 3.5mm jack has been provided on the right side, the volume rocker button works well and is intuitively designed. The Micro USB port also sits on the right, below a pretty decent camera button. The SIM is a pain to remove, unless you have long nails. Compared to this, the Bold 9700 has a flawless SIM tray.

In-call quality is very good, the Curve 8900 has a really

sweet antenna – no dropped calls. The loudspeaker is pretty loud at maximum volume, but distorts, even at lower volumes. Vocals are understandable, but music isn't much fun. The headset offers good quality and good volumes. Camera quality is mediocre – decent colour, but sharpness is ordinary.

Verdict

Recent price slashes have kept the Curve 8900 competitive – it's a good handset for the price, although at Rs. 20,000 odd, you could also pick up Nokia's lovely E72 that will match the Blackberry for nearly all features and add a couple to the table.



Blackberry Curve 8900

Business phones above Rs. 20,000

Nokia E72

The E72 joins above the E71 near the top of the line. The phone offers great performance and usability across its many means of communication, from video calls to IM, email to SMS, MMS to VoIP, and of course, voice calls.

The E72 is available in seven different colours, offers 3G support (HSDPA 10.2Mbps and

HSUPA 2Mbps), and has a 2.4-inch QVGA (320x240) screen. Running on the Symbian Series 60 v3.2 OS, the phone's UI on its widescreen is not very pleasing to the eye, but then again, as a business phone, it is functional but not cluttered, which is what matters. The phone has a business size battery as well, at 1500mAh. Our test phone lasted over two days on a single charge, even when using GPS and WiFi, and making calls.

The optical track pad is bounded by the D-pad, which seriously limits the easy flick-to-use navigation and scrolling that is possible on the optical track pads of comparable BlackBerry phones. While the still camera is good, the video resolution of VGA@15fps is quite low. DivX support is not free. No UI auto-rotate when in camera mode and no dedicated camera key.

On the whole, the phone offers some great call clarity through the earpiece, loudspeaker and handsfree, and we experienced no call dropping in our testing. The keypad is well designed, with easy to press buttons that are spaced well-apart in an acceptable trade-off with a large form factor. The dedicated mail, home, contacts, and calendar keys are very useful, and well-placed. The flashlight is also nice touch, unexpected on a business phone.

Verdict

The phone definitely serves its business messaging function well. Apart from a small screen size and video recording resolution, there is not much we can fault the E72 for. Though it offers pretty good value for money when you take into account its great features, it still can't be



Nokia E72

compared to the much cheaper full-QWERTY, LG GW550, but it is definitely a much better buy if you have the money. In terms of free Ovi Maps and turn-by-turn voice navigation, it compares well against the similarly priced Garmin-Asus Nuvifone M10, with accuracy levels and directions that are at par the navigator phone. The Nuvifone M10 goes one step ahead though, with its more detailed NAVTEQ Maps, as well as its much larger screen making for easier visual navigation.

Blackberry Bold 9000

The biggest of the Blackberry devices in test, it is quite a handful – literally. The Bold 9000 is boldly large, and none the worse for it. The device is well build, and the entire rear (that is dominated by a huge battery cover) is leather – very neat and novel looking (and feeling!). We also think the larger dimensions mean a better keypad as it gets a touch more spacing – typing is the proverbial piece of cake – getting emails written is a snap. There is a downside too – the Bold 9000 might be too large for some hands, and makes